

Plastic in Our Oceans

Year 6 reading comprehension · Information text · 13 marks · About 30 minutes

A growing problem

Plastic is cheap, light and strong, which is why it is used for everything from drinks bottles to toys. But those same qualities have created a serious problem. Scientists estimate that millions of tonnes of plastic end up in the world's oceans every year. Much of it is washed into the sea by rivers or blown from beaches and rubbish tips.

Plastic does not rot away like paper or food. Instead, it breaks into smaller and smaller pieces, called microplastics, which can stay in the water for hundreds of years.

Hidden harm

Sea creatures often mistake plastic for food. Sea turtles, for example, may swallow floating plastic bags because they look like jellyfish. Seabirds and fish can also eat tiny pieces, which may make them ill. Researchers have even found microplastics in the deep sea and in Arctic ice. Fishing nets that are lost or thrown away at sea can also trap dolphins, seals and turtles, which is sometimes called ghost fishing.

The problem does not stop at the water's edge. Microplastics are so small that they can travel up the food chain: tiny sea creatures eat them, larger fish eat those creatures, and eventually some of the plastic may end up on our own plates. Scientists are still studying what this might mean for human health, and they do not yet agree on how serious the risk is.

What can be done?

Many people believe that the solution begins with all of us. Using reusable bottles and bags, recycling carefully and avoiding single-use plastic can all reduce the amount of waste. Some engineers are also developing nets and barriers to collect rubbish from rivers before it reaches the sea. Several countries have already taxed or banned plastic carrier bags, and in the UK, volunteers now find far fewer bags on beaches than before the charge began. However, many experts argue that these efforts will not be enough unless governments and companies also make less plastic in the first place.

1. What are very small pieces of broken-down plastic called? (1 mark)

2. The text says scientists “estimate” that millions of tonnes of plastic enter the sea each year. What does the word “estimate” suggest about this number? (2 marks)

3. Give two reasons why plastic is used for so many things. (1 mark)

4. The writer says, “those same qualities have created a serious problem”. What does this sentence mean? Which qualities is the writer talking about? (2 marks)

5. Why is plastic that looks like food especially dangerous for sea animals? (2 marks)

6. Summarise the section “What can be done?” in two sentences. (2 marks)

7. Who does the writer seem to think must do most to solve the problem: individuals, or governments and companies? Use evidence from the text. (2 marks)

8. Choose the statement that best sums up the whole text. Write its letter. (1 mark)

- A. Plastic is cheap, light and strong, so countries should make much more of it every single year.
- B. Sea turtles are the only animals that are harmed by plastic floating in the world’s oceans.
- C. Plastic harms sea life, and fixing it takes action from people, governments and companies.
- D. Recycling bottles and bags at home has already solved the problem of plastic in the sea.

Answer: _____

Writing task: Write a persuasive paragraph encouraging your school to use less single-use plastic.
